

63.8 THE ZERO ARTICLE AND GENERIC "THE"

The zero article can be used with plural nouns to talk about a class of things in general. This can also be done with the definite article, plus a singular noun.

Referring to an invention, not an individual telescope.

Telescopes
The telescopes } changed the way we see the night sky.



Referring to a species of animal, not an individual animal.

Cheetahs
The cheetahs } can run faster than any other land animal.



Referring to a type of musical instrument, not an individual instrument.

Violins are
The violin is } often the key instrument in an orchestra.



63.9 DEFINITE AND INDEFINITE ARTICLES WITH NAMES

The zero article is normally used with the name of a person.

This is my uncle, **Neil Armstrong**.



The definite article is used before a person's name to differentiate them from another person with the same name.

In this case, "the" is pronounced "thee."

He's not **the Neil Armstrong**, is he?
[He isn't the famous person with that name, is he?]



The indefinite article is used when the focus is on a particular name, rather than the person.

I'm afraid there isn't
a **"Joseph Bloggs"** on the list.
[The particular name given is not on the list.]

